

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 2

Lafz · The categories of Kalimah

1. Lafz

The word *lafz* generally means **to throw**; its plural is *alfaz*. In terminology *lafz* means مَا يَتَلَفَّظُ بِهِ الْإِنْسَانُ — that which a human being utters.

Words come into being through the joining of letters and *harakaat*. A letter on its own carries no complete sound; only when a *harakah* is placed on it can it be pronounced, and when several voiced letters gather in order, a word is formed.

How letters and harakaat build a word

Word	Its letters and harakaat
حُرُوف	ح + ر + و + ف
عَلَامَات	ع + ل + ا + م + ا + ت
لَفْظ	ل + ف + ظ

Waqf and the harakah on the final letter

In the words above, no *harakah* is shown on the final letter of حُرُوف, عَلَامَات or لَفْظ. In reality, however, every Arabic word does carry some *harakah* on its final letter too. In the state of *waqf* (pausing) that final vowel is simply not pronounced; the letter is read as *sakin* instead.

Rule: In Arabic, every letter except the *Alif* must carry either a *harakah* or a *sukoon*. That is why the final letters of حُرُوف, عَلَامَات and لَفْظ do in fact carry a vowel, though *waqf* keeps it from being shown or sounded.

The harakah before an Alif

If a *harakah* or a *sukoon* appears on an *Alif*, it is no longer an *Alif* but a *Hamzah*. In the word عَلامَات the meem carries a zabar and the alif after it is bare.

Rule: Wherever an *Alif* occurs in Arabic, the letter before it always carries a **zabar**. A zer or a pesh cannot come before an *Alif*.

2. The categories of Lafz

Lafz falls into two categories: **meaningful** and **meaningless**.

Category	Definition	Examples
Muhmal	A word that carries no meaning	wani, woti, waay
Kalimah (Mawdu')	A word that carries a meaning	water, bread, tea

A meaningless word is called *Muhmal* and a meaningful word is called *Kalimah*. In terminology a meaningful word is also called *Mawdu'*.

The two further categories of a meaningful word

Category	Definition	Example
Mufrad	A single word that carries meaning. This is what is called a <i>Kalimah</i> .	طَاوِلَة (table)
Murakkab	A word made up of two or more <i>Kalimat</i>	الْجَوَّالُ جَدِيدٌ (the mobile is new)

A special point: Every word in the Qur'an is a *Kalimah*, that is, meaningful. Nothing in the Speech of Allah is *Muhmal* or purposeless.

3. The categories of Kalimah

Kalimah has three categories: *Ism*, *Fi'l* and *Harf*. Every word of the Qur'an is either an *Ism*, or a *Fi'l*, or a *Harf*. *Ism* and *Fi'l* are the primary and principal categories, while the *Harf* assists them both.

Category	Definition	Example
Ism	A <i>Kalimah</i> that conveys its meaning without joining another <i>Kalimah</i> , and in which none of the three tenses is found	الْبَصْرَةُ

Category	Definition	Example
Fi'l	A Kalimah that conveys its meaning without joining another Kalimah, and in which one of the three tenses is found	سِرْتُ
Harf	A Kalimah that does not convey its meaning without joining another Kalimah	مِنْ ، إِلَى

Take the sentence سِرْتُ مِنَ الْبَصْرَةِ إِلَى الْكُوفَةِ (I travelled from Basrah to Kufah). Here سِرْتُ is a *Fi'l* because past time is found in it. الْبَصْرَةُ and الْكُوفَةُ are *Ism* because no tense is found in them. And مِنْ and إِلَى are *Harf*, because on their own they do not convey their meanings of beginning and end.

4. The Alamaat of Ism, Fi'l and Harf

Everything has some sign by which it is known. With the *alamaat* below, the words of any Arabic sentence can be told apart.

Alamaat of the Ism

- Beginning with *alif lam*, as in الْحَمْدُ
- Ending with *Tanween*, as in زَيْدٌ
- Being *Tathniyah* or *Jam'*, as in كِتَابَانِ and مُسْلِمُونَ
- Being *Mudhakkar* or *Mu'annath*, as in ضَارِبٌ and ضَارِيَةٌ
- Beginning with a *Harfun Nida*, as in يَا يُوسُفُ
- Beginning with a *Harful Jarr*, as in فِي الْقَافِلَةِ
- Being *Mawsuf*, *Mansub*, *Mudaf*, *Mudaf Ilayh* or *Musaghghar*, as in حُسَيْنٌ

Alamaat of the Fi'l

- Being *Madi*, *Mudari'* or *Amr*, as in نَصَرَ ، يَنْصُرُ ، أَنْصُرُ
- Beginning with the *La* of *nahi*, or with *Qad*, *Sa* or *Sawf*, as in لَا تَنْصُرْ ، قَدْ دَخَلَ ، سَيَعْلَمُ ، سَوْفَ
- Beginning with one of the *Huroof ul Jawazim* or *Huroof un Nawasib*, as in لَمْ يَضْرِبْ ، لَنْ يَضْرِبَ
- Ending with a *Nun ut Ta'keed* or a *Taa' Sakinah*, as in دَخَلْتُ ، لَيَضْرِبَنَّ

Alamah of the Harf

The mark of a *Harf* is that none of the *alamaat* of the *Ism* or the *Fi'l* is present in it. Its function is to create a link between two *Isms*, two *Fi'ls* or two sentences, as in *زَيْدٌ فِي الدَّارِ* and *إِنْ تَضْرِبْ أَضْرَبْ*.

5. Jumla Ismiyyah and Jumla Fi'liyyah

Sentences are built from these same *Kalimat*. When two or more of them combine to convey a complete idea to the listener, the result is called a **Murakkab Mufeed**, also called **Jumlah**, **Kalam** and **Murakkab Tamm**, as in *زَيْدٌ وَكَدٌ نَجِيبٌ* (Zayd is a well-bred boy).

And if two words together still do not complete an idea, the result is a **Murakkab Ghayr Mufeed** or **Murakkab Naqis**, as in *رَجُلٌ صَالِحٌ* (a righteous man) — the listener is left waiting for more.

A sentence is of two kinds:

Kind of sentence	Definition	Example
Jumla Ismiyyah	A sentence composed of a Muftada and a Khabar. The Muftada is the Ism being spoken about, and the Khabar is what is said about it.	زَيْدٌ عَاقِلٌ (Zayd is intelligent)
Jumla Fi'liyyah	A sentence composed of a Fi'l and a Fa'il. The Fa'il is the Ism preceded by a Fi'l, with that Fi'l standing by it.	جَاءَ زَيْدٌ (Zayd came)

A further division: By whether truth or falsehood can be attributed to it, a sentence divides again. A sentence whose speaker can be called truthful or untruthful is a **Jumla Khabariyyah**, as in *زَيْدٌ ذَكِيٌّ*. A sentence whose speaker can be called neither is a **Jumla Insha'iyyah**, as in *إِضْرِبْ* (strike!). *Amr*, *Nahi*, *Istifham*, *Tamanni*, *Qasam*, *Du'a* and *Nida* are all forms of *Jumla Insha'iyyah*.

6. The letters that do not join what follows

Of the twenty-eight Arabic letters, six do not join to the letter that follows them:

ا	د	ذ	ر	ز	و
---	---	---	---	---	---

Apart from these six, every other letter is written joined to the one after it.

7. Arabic script and Qur'anic script

Two scripts are in use for Arabic: ordinary Arabic script and Qur'anic script. In ordinary Arabic script the word for book is written just as it is in Urdu, whereas in the Qur'an the same word appears differently. In some *Masahif* it is written with a standing zabar over the taa', and in others with a zabar followed by an alif. This shows that the Arabic language and the Qur'anic script differ in the way words are written.

Urdu	Arabic	Qur'anic script	
kitab	كِتَاب	اَلْكِتَابِ	اَلْكِتَابِ

8. Taa' Daraz and Taa' Marbutah

The letter taa' has two forms in Arabic: the *Taa' Daraz* (the long taa'), also called *Taa' Mabsutah*, and the round ة, called *Taa' Marbutah*.

Form	Where it occurs in a word	Examples
Taa' Daraz (ت)	Beginning, middle and end — all three positions	تَائِب ، كُتِب ، بِنْتُ
Taa' Marbutah (ة)	Only at the end of a word	جَنَّة ، اِبْنَةُ ، كَلِمَةُ

The round ة can never come at the beginning or in the middle of a word. The word اِبْنَةُ means daughter.

The difference in pronunciation

On a long taa', in the state of *waqf* the taa' sound is pronounced, as in بِنْتُ ، أُخْتُ ، جَنَّات . On the round ة, by contrast, in *waqf* the taa' sound is not pronounced; it is read like an h instead.

Word	In the state of Waqf	When joined to the next word
كَلِمَةُ	كَلِمَہ	كَلِمَتُ ...
آيَةُ	آيَہ	آيَتُ ...
جَنَّة	جَنَّہ	جَنَّتُ ...

If a word with a round ة is joined to the word after it, the sound of the round ة changes into that of a long taa', as in رَحِمَتْ اللّٰهَ.

Rule: The letter before a round **و** always carries a zabar.

Summary

1. Lafz literally means to throw; its plural is alfaz. In terminology it is that which a human being utters.
2. Words come into being through the joining of letters and harakaat.
3. Every letter except the Alif must carry a harakah or a sukoon; in waqf the final vowel is not sounded.
4. The letter before an Alif always carries a zabar; a zer or a pesh cannot come there.
5. Lafz is of two kinds: the meaningless is Muhmal and the meaningful is Kalimah. A meaningful word divides further into Mufrad and Murakkab.
6. Every word of the Qur'an is a Kalimah, that is, meaningful.
7. Kalimah has three categories: Ism, Fi'l and Harf. Ism and Fi'l are primary; the Harf assists them.
8. No tense is found in an Ism, tense is found in a Fi'l, and a Harf does not convey its meaning on its own.
9. Alif lam and Tanween are marks of an Ism, while the Madi, Mudari' and Amr forms are marks of a Fi'l.
10. Two kinds of sentence are built from Kalimat: Jumla Ismiyyah (Muftada + Khabar) and Jumla Fi'liyyah (Fi'l + Fa'il).
11. Six letters — ا، د، ذ، ر، ز، و — do not join to the letter that follows them.
12. Arabic script and Qur'anic script differ, as in كُتِبَ and كَتَّاب.
13. The Taa' Daraz can occur at the beginning, middle and end of a word, while the round ة occurs only at the end.
14. In waqf the round ة is read like an h, and when joined it becomes a taa'.

Exercise

1. Define Lafz and explain the difference between Muhmal and Kalimah with examples.
 2. Break the following words into their letters and harakaat: حُرُوفٌ , عَلامَاتٌ , لَفْظٌ.
 3. What happens to the final letter of a word in the state of waqf?
 4. Which harakah comes before an Alif, and which cannot?
 5. Define all three categories of Kalimah, each with one example.
 6. Separate the Ism, Fi'l and Harf in the following sentence: سِرْتُ مِنَ الْبَصْرَةِ إِلَى الْكُوفَةِ.
 7. Explain the difference between Jumla Ismiyyah and Jumla Fi'liyyah with examples.
 8. Write the six letters that do not join to the letter after them.
 9. Explain the difference between Taa' Daraz and Taa' Marbutah, giving two examples of each.
 10. Write the following words as they are read in waqf: كَلِمَةٌ , آيَةٌ , جَنَّةٌ.
-

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ